

centre services also represent burgeoning areas. For instance, we are seeing the emergence of cloud services in India powered by thousands of NVIDIA H100 GPUs, which are the workhorses of the new GenAI factories.

To seize these opportunities, India must enhance its startup ecosystem. This involves encouraging entrepreneurship, expanding incubation and acceleration infrastructure, and providing robust training for professionals. A strong mentoring network is vital, as is the need to retain startups within India by revisiting tax laws and providing favourable conditions for domestic capital formation. We must replicate startup grants like Karnataka's 'Elevate' programme. The government can also stimulate growth by encouraging procurement of domestic SaaS products and services.

3. Technology fund: The third pillar, a robust technology fund, is essential for sustained innovation. I propose three types of funds.

↘ **Research fund:** Modelled on the National Mission on Interdisciplinary Cyber Physical Systems (NMICPS), which I chair. It aims to create new technologies with guaranteed funding for 5-10 years. Institutions selected on a competitive basis are tasked with achieving specific goals related to product or startup creation.

↘ **Venture capital (VC) fund:** It is designed to support diverse startups, investing at the seed or Series A stage alongside selected VC funds. This fund specifically targets underrepresented areas, such as the Northeast, assistive technologies and women-promoted ventures.

↘ **Dedicated deep tech fund:** This will fund deep tech startups, those that emerge as startups from research labs. These startups become the product and technology companies of tomorrow and sell to the world.

4. Branding and capacity-building activities: The fourth pillar is around brand- and capacity-building activities that encompass all services, including IT/ ITES, creative, R&D, global capability centres (GCCs), data centres and digital technology startups. This requires helping these organisations scale up. Capability-building will require capacity-building in skilling and training in emerging technologies. It is also essential to grow the talent pool, especially in tier-2/ 3 cities and rural areas, and promote regions close to existing educational hubs such as IIT Dharwad, IIT Indore and IIM Lucknow. Industry organisations like NASSCOM and CII, with support from government bodies like the Department for Promotion of Industry and Internal Trade (DPIIT) and Invest India, have an important role to play here.

5. Societal impact: While Indian companies must expand into global markets, they must also focus on creating significant societal impact within the country. India's extraordinary achievements through its digital public infrastructure (DPI) such as Aadhaar (for identity), UPI (for payments), and Open Network for Digital Commerce (ONDC) have helped it achieve sustainable development in seven years, which otherwise might have taken over 47 years. Now, homegrown AI large-language models (LLMs) around a multitude of Indian languages are being created under the Bhashini initiative of the government. Ultimately, these DPIs should empower the Indian farmer, government schoolteachers and students, MSMEs and citizens. Through efforts like MOSIP (Modular Open Source Identity Platform) at IIIT Bangalore, India is already exporting these DPIs to other countries as well.

By capitalising on opportunities for revenue expansion and creation, establishing a robust technology fund, investing in brand- and capacity-building activities, and prioritising sustainable societal impact, India is poised to lead the world's digital revolution.

The path is clear; the time to act is now. ■

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